Strong Arms

By Albert Lujan

At the age of six I declared my love, my desire, my utter need out loud, to the image on the smooth convex surface of my family's Zenith color television console. From my seat on the tangled shag of the living room I was levitated forward by a force so magnetic that it pulled my tongue from my mouth and my eyes from their sockets, to vibrate only inches from the screen. It pulled the words from my mouth. "I want you."

INTRODUCTION

Toys have always played an important role in enriching children's lives. They often reflect the culture of the times and are an indicator of historical changes and trends in society. Although today's toys may seem very different from those of years past, the purpose of toys has always been the same: to bring laughter and joy, and to create opportunities for learning and developmental growth. Maybe you can remember the power of the first toy you fell in love with. . . Strong Arms by Albert Lujan.

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I vowed to sit there, in front of the television, until I saw again the commercial that so transfixed me; a vow that only lasted till 8:30, my bedtime. I swore I would resume my vigil at dawn. I would see it again. See him again. There, I said it. Not out loud, of course, but secretly, with conviction and desire.

Who was he? Why hadn't I heard mention of him in the schoolyard or park? All night I thrashed these questions around, between dreaming and waking. He was on my mind when I woke up. It seemed I'd imagined him, but my dreams were so detailed that I knew, deep down, he was real.

That next morning, before school and between bites of Alpha-Bits cereal, he appeared to me again, on Channel 2.

"Mom, hurry mira lookit, hurry mira lookit! The one I told you about. Hur-ryyy!" I sprayed milk and bits through my nose across the table as I bolted for the TV. Clearly she didn't sense the urgency in my screams. By

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the time she reached the living room, from the kitchen, where she wrapped a beans-and-rice burrito for my lunch, he was gone.

It was too late to pretend that I felt sick in order to spend the day in front of the TV. A successful sick act had to begin the night before or the minute she woke me up. Plan B had me rummaging through the medicine chest before breakfast for something that would have the school nurse calling home to let my mother know she was sending me home for the day. I examined the various pills of ever color and shape. I resisted eating the Hershey-imitation Ex-Lax. I tried that the day Luke and Laura were scheduled to be married on General Hospital. It worked, only I spent the whole day on the toilet and missed it all. I pushed the children's multi vitamins off to the side and selected the bottle with the baby-blue colored pills in it. The label read "Midol." I popped the top and poured three into my pocket. After all, I wasn't suicidal, I was in love.

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On the walk to school I ate the pills from my pocket. I tasted the chalky bitterness and gagged. I silently beckoned to Him. I mouth His name. Called it out. Even chanted it. Armstrong. Mr. Stretch Armstrong from Hasbro. Hasbro – where was that magical country? I wondered. Strong arms. Yes, clearly he was very strong. Buff like the Tasmanian Devil but in complete control. Stronger than any Tonka truck I'd ever owned and destroyed. He had powerful arms with shoulders out to there and legs so muscular it was clear he would never be able to cross them like a girl, even if he wanted to. He had a Bob's Big Boy soft-serve chocolate ice cream flip going on. Sexy, of course, but in a manly way. Painfully blue eyes. He held a sensual half-grin/half-snarl that said, "I'll be your special friend, but don't [mess] with me 'cuz I could still kill you with my hands if I have to."

Stretch was quite confident too. Proud of his hard-earned physique. All he ever ran around in was a pair of Speedos. Red. They looked like they were painted on. He

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was the color of Band-Aids. G.I. Joe and that old sissy, Ken, were obviously ashamed of their scrawny bodies. I was quite disappointed in them, considering how hard it was to get their clothes off.

At school I couldn't concentrate. I felt kind of lightheaded and kept needing to pee. At my desk I misspelled his name over and over again on my H.R. Puffinstuff notebook. If I got him for Christmas I would never mistreat him. If I got him for my birthday I would cuddle him. Rest him on my chest like some mini-manchild. Feed him mini-muscle bars so that he could have the strength to put Ken in a headlock.

At lunchtime, after I threw away my burrito, I stood in line in the cafeteria holding my bile-yellow fiberglass tray loaded with bile-yellow food. The guy in front of me, this gangly third grader, kept reaching around, checking the contents of his book bag with one hand and trying to balance the tray with the other. It was as if he were afraid some bully was gonna steal his math book or

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something. Or someone. I saw it. From the edge of the book bag flap I saw it protruding like some obscene, pink udder. Like and arm. A strong arm.

Oh my God. Only one day after the commercial aired for the first time. How hard did he have to whine to get him so soon? And he had the nerve to bring Stretch to school with him. Nine months 'til Christmas, ten 'til my birthday. It just wasn't fair.

By the time we reached the milk I was hyperventilating. I was so enraged and jealous that I started gagging. Everyone around me was going "eeiiuu" and moving away. I instantly reacted. I jerked forward, snatched Stretch from the backpack, dropped him onto my tray, pulled my tray to my chest, and spilled creamed-corn and fruit cocktail on myself. Still I held him tight next to my thumping heart and obscured him. I was delirious and a little nauseous. The little punk out a scream.

The Lord works in a mysterious ways, 'cuz all of a sudden

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projectile vomit sprayed from my smiling face. I was wild. Kids ran in all direction. Like a far-reaching sprinkler, I caught most of them on their pants legs. Everyone screamed. It was pandemonium. They cleared out a wide-open get-away path and I took it, laughing, gurgling, almost drowning in my barf, clutching the tray to my chest. I was halfway out the cafeteria before I heard the third grader scream, "Hey, puke-boy's got my doll!"

Doll? Is that all he thought Stretch was? Some toy to stuff into a chest like some old deflated Hoppity-Hop? I thought not. He really didn't deserve him. I ducked in the teachers' restroom. The ladies'. Jumped into a stall. "Oh, Stretch," I murmured. "But they're coming for us. They'll want to take you from me." There was nowhere to hide him. He didn't fit in my pockets. I tried to stuff him into my pants and that was kinda nice but really obvious. I could hear them outside. They had followed the trail of puke and food. "You're mine, Stretch, forever. No matter what," I vowed.

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I pulled the packet that contained the napkin, straw, and 'spork' that had stuck to my shirt. "Before they take you from me, my love, we must take the blood oath." Yes, I was a bit melodramatic for six years old. I slashed the back of my hand with the spork, but getting through Stretch's skin was a little harder. It took a couple of hard jabs with my pencil to finally puncture the tough hide on his arm.

I put my bleeding hand to his face. I held him over my face and squeezed out his pink, gummy insides, which dangled sensuously and thick like melted mozzarella. I put my mouth over his whole arm and sucked it. Like it was my thumb. I sucked his insides into me. It tasted like Ponds cold cream and paste. Tears ran down my face. I sucked until I passed out.

I woke up in the hospital. His nontoxic goop lined my insides and blocked my air passage. A 125-year-old nurse told me that I had turned blue, "…just like a Smurf." I

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had to have my stomach pumped.

At the hospital my parents, and some relatives whom I only saw on Easter and Christmas, watched me nervously, praying the rosary over me and pulling my arm with the I.V. in it to make the sign of the cross. They lavished on me welcomed kisses, Spanish comic books I couldn't figure out, and a Lite-Brite set with a note taped to the top of it that read, "Do not swallow the pegs! They are not JUJU-BEES!" I had a strange feeling that from then on everybody would be watching what I ate very closely.

That night I fell asleep with the soft, colorfully glowing Lite-Brite set clutched to my chest. On it was the first message I wrote. My first love letter: "I 'heart' S.A. 4-ever."

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